Check the evidence you prefer

Notice selective attention and build a check that could change your mind.

Suggested teaching time: 30 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None

Students will be able to

- Identify a stated pattern of selecting agreeable evidence.
- Apply the same quality standards to supportive and critical evidence.
- Propose a relevant outcome measure that can reveal a mistake.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no student devices required.
- Instructor guide with model answers, kept separate from the handout.
- Read the three scenarios and their model answers.
- Print the three-page handout or display one activity at a time.
- Explain that all scenarios and figures are invented for reasoning practice.

Teaching sequence

5 min	**Notice selective reading.** Learners complete the headline warm-up. Focus on the stated behavior; do not infer hidden motives or whether the underlying claim is true.
10 min	**Build a fair checking plan.** Pairs complete the study-app activity. Check that their plan includes critical reviews and a measure of learning.
8 min	**Discuss what a bias does not prove.** Use the discussion prompts and model answer to separate a flawed checking process from the truth of the claim.
7 min	**Apply the checking method.** Learners complete the planner exit ticket independently. Assess selection, consistent standards, and a relevant outcome measure.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / Only the helpful headlines

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Confirmation bias: A tendency to favor information that fits what we already believe or want to believe.

Evidence standard: A rule for judging evidence quality, applied consistently to different conclusions.

Scenario

Invented scenario: Mina believes morning classes help learning. She saves three headlines agreeing with her and ignores two disagreeing headlines because she says, 'I only want support for my view.' She has not read any study methods.

Student output: Write the selection pattern and one fair next step.

1. Identify which evidence Mina accepts and avoids.

2. Explain how that choice favors her existing view.

3. Propose a next step that uses the same evidence standards for both sides.

Student success check: Have you identified the stated behavior without declaring her belief true or false?

Model answer

Mina selects agreement and avoids disagreement, favoring her prior view. She should inspect the methods and learning measures behind all five reports using the same criteria, rather than judging by headline agreement.

Why this meets the task: The answer diagnoses selective attention from explicit facts and proposes a check; it does not decide the claim from the bias alone.

Main activity / Does the study app help?

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: After buying a study app, Sam reads six glowing reviews and skips four detailed critical reviews because 'they will only make me doubt my choice'. Sam concludes the app must improve learning. No learning results have been collected.

Student output: Write the selection pattern, a three-step checking plan, and a learning measure with an explanation.

1. Identify the evidence Sam selects and the evidence Sam avoids, and explain the direction of the preference.
2. Write a three-step checking plan: include both kinds of reviews, use the same quality criteria for them, and collect a learning measure rather than relying only on praise.
3. Name a specific learning measure, such as a delayed quiz on comparable material, and say why review popularity alone is insufficient.

Student success check: Does your plan make it possible to discover that the purchase was unhelpful, or only reassure Sam?

Model answer

Sam favours praise that confirms the purchase and avoids criticism that could challenge it. Plan: read all ten reviews; assess each for relevant experience and checkable evidence using the same criteria; compare delayed-quiz performance on comparable material studied with and without the app under similar conditions. Positive reviews show approval, not necessarily better learning.

Why this meets the task: It describes the selective attention and turns a vague request to 'be unbiased' into concrete checks capable of revealing a mistake.

Exit ticket / Defending a new planner

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: After buying a planner app, Jo reads eight positive reviews and ignores three detailed complaints because 'I do not want to regret buying it'. Jo concludes the app reduces missed deadlines. No deadline records have been collected.

Student output: Write the biased selection and a three-step checking plan with a relevant measure.

1. Identify the evidence Jo chooses and avoids, and the direction of the preference.
2. Plan to read both kinds of review and apply the same quality criteria.
3. Name a comparison using missed deadlines. You may compare rates: missed deadlines divided by total deadlines, using comparable workloads and periods. Explain why positive reviews alone do not answer the claim.

Student success check: Could the plan reveal that the app does not reduce missed deadlines?

Model answer

Jo favors approval and avoids criticism of the purchase. Plan: read all eleven reviews; judge each for relevant experience and checkable evidence; compare missed-deadline rates with and without the app for similar workloads. A rate is missed deadlines divided by total deadlines. Praise measures approval, not necessarily fewer missed deadlines.

Why this meets the task: The plan treats both sides consistently and measures the claimed outcome. A fair comparison would still need attention to workload and other differences.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The stated selective behavior and its direction are identified accurately.
- The plan applies the same quality criteria to supportive and critical evidence.
- The proposed outcome measure addresses the claim and can reveal an unhelpful result.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Does finding bias show the app is ineffective?

Listen for: No. It shows a problem with how the claim was checked. Better evidence may support or undermine the claim.

Must positive and negative reviews receive equal weight?

Listen for: No. Apply equal standards, then weight the reviews according to their evidence quality. Equal numbers or equal conclusions are not required.

Common confusions

Calling someone biased settles the factual question. Describe the behavior and inspect the evidence. A flawed process does not itself make a conclusion false.

Being fair means giving all reviews equal weight. Use the same criteria; more relevant, checkable evidence can deserve more weight.

Bias requires a hidden bad motive. These cases state the selective behavior directly. Do not claim access to thoughts or motives not supplied.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Use two columns, selected and avoided, before writing the plan. Offer review-quality questions: Is the experience relevant? Can the claim be checked? Expected example: read praise and criticism, check both for relevant experience and evidence, then compare a learning outcome.

More challenge: Ask: If one negative review gives detailed learning results and six positive reviews only say "great", should their counts decide? Expected response: no; inspect methods and relevance, and do not assume either praise or criticism is reliable solely from its direction.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=cognitive_biases#workbench